

Bystanders and Reporters: Who Acts Against Illegal Online Content?

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Friederike Quint¹, Yannis Theocharis¹, Spyros Kosmidis²,
and Margaret E. Roberts³

Abstract

Harmful and illegal content on social media is widespread, but what should be taken down is widely disputed, creating ongoing challenges for resolving the tension between free speech and user safety. User reporting is a key mechanism for addressing such content, yet little is known about who reports, what motivates them, and how they compare to the general population. We study these questions using two datasets: (1) a unique survey with individuals verified to have previously reported potentially illegal content to a third-party organization in Germany and (2) a quota-based sample approximating the German population. We show that individuals who have previously reported potentially illegal content via a third-party reporting service represent a distinct, civically engaged subset of users. They tend to be older, more often men than women, highly educated, highly politically active, and markedly left-leaning. They are not politically representative of the German population and take a distinctly different position when balancing free speech and protection from harm, putting more emphasis on protecting from harm. Reporting users' motivations appear primarily civic-minded rather than reactive, especially among those who do it frequently and those intervening on behalf of others. These insights highlight reporting as a form of digital civic participation and offer perspectives relevant for understanding political engagement online, platform governance, user agency, and trust and safety regulation.

Keywords

content moderation, social media, user reporting, trusted flagger, political behavior

Introduction

Harmful content remains widespread on social media; however, what content should be removed is disputed, posing challenges for resolving the tension between free speech and user safety. To combat harmful – and sometimes illegal – content, platforms have traditionally relied not only on automated detection and human moderators but also on user flagging and reporting (Singhal et al., 2023). User-centered moderation, one of the earliest forms of moderation on social media (York, 2022), has increasingly moved to the forefront – epitomized by X's (Twitter's) 2021 Birdwatch program, later rebranded on X as Community Notes. The shift accelerated in January 2025, when Meta's CEO Mark Zuckerberg announced that the company would end U.S. fact-checking and rely increasingly on users reporting content before action is taken by Meta (Isaac & Schleifer, 2025). Coupled with Meta's termination of third-party fact-checking – reversing years of prioritizing automation (Meta, 2020) – these moves underscore renewed reliance and higher responsibilities on users.

User reporting seems democratic in nature, but limited flagging options and opaque enforcement often leave users frustrated and doubtful that their reports matter (Crawford & Gillespie, 2016; Jhaver & Zhang, 2023). Many users abandon reports when categories are unclear or outcomes uncertain, reinforcing perceptions of arbitrariness (Blackwell et al., 2018; DiFranzo et al., 2018). In response to these limitations, some countries have established independent third-party reporting portals that allow citizens to report abusive or potentially illegal content outside of platform environments.

¹Technical University of Munich, Germany

²Oxford University, UK

³University of California, San Diego, USA

Corresponding Author:

Friederike Quint, Department of Governance, Munich School of Politics and Public Policy, Technical University of Munich, Richard-Wagner-Straße 1, Munich 80333, Germany.

Email: friederike.quint@tum.de

